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Jeanette Winterson's *The Gap of Time* in the Caesura of the Time That is Left

Tatiana Golban

Department of English Language and Literature, Tekirdağ Namık Kemal University, Türkiye

ABSTRACT
The present study engages comparatively with William Shakespeare's play *The Winter's Tale* (1611) and Jeanette Winterson's novel *The Gap of Time* (2015) and focuses on the major conceit of both texts – the gap of time. The vague "gap" in Shakespeare's play inspires Jeanette Winterson, who opens in *The Gap of Time* a space for the reflection on the poetics of "gaps" in the artistic representation. This paper has a 2-fold purpose. The first is to examine Winterson's work through the lens of Agamben's concept of "messianic time," in which the artist, aware of the temporal gap between the creation and eschaton, attempts to depict in art the experience of "the time that is left," "the time which takes to come to an end, to accomplish itself." The second aim of this study is to reveal how Winterson's *The Gap of Time*, an adaptation of Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale*, functions as a caesura, a meta-linguistic opening of indeterminate plasticity and mobility, a work which, like an unsettled interval, assumes the form of a "cover" and of a literary manifesto that expresses the tensions caused by transformation of structure, mode, and genre, but mostly the conflict between past and present, lost and found, original and adaptation.

"What's past is prologue" (*The Tempest*, II, I, 257)

"though metst with things dying, I with things new born" (*The Winter's Tale*, III, iii, 110–111)

"The fixture of her eye has motion in't,/As we are mocked with art" (*The Winter's Tale*, V, iii, 67–8)

In Act IV, Scene 1 of William Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale* (1611), the audience is surprised by the arrival on stage of the most elusive character – Time – who, in an amazing act of theatrical bravado, announces "a wide gap" of time, an act that has bewildered many artists to this day. The hourglass, a traditional accompaniment to Time, is turned over midway through his speech, alerting the spectators to the unusual "hour" in which they will witness their "social order turned upside down" (Pitcher, 77). Personified as "Witness, Destroyer, Creator, and Revealer" (Rundus, 123), Shakespeare's Time instructs the spectators to take a leap of faith, which is not perceived as a "crime," and slide "o'er sixteen years and leave the growth untried/Of that wide gap . . . " (IV, i, 6–7). While this moment clearly pays tribute to the power of time, the "gap" opened in Shakespeare's play has challenged many artists and writers who have attempted to grasp its rich meaning, frequently becoming a starting point for new reflections on the endless possible "gaps" in artistic representation.

This is evident in Jeanette Winterson's novel *The Gap of Time*, which draws its inspiration from the ambiguous "gap" opened in Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale* (1611). Winterson describes this play as a "talismanic work" that she has worked with "in many disguises for many years," a work that is

CONTACT Tatiana Golban tgolban@nku.edu.tr Faculty of Science and Letters, Department of English Language and Literature, Tekirdağ Namık Kemal University, Değirmenaltı Campus, Süleymanpaşa/Tekirdağ 59030, Turkey
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"carried around and that carry us around" (*The Guardian*). Therefore, when the Hogarth Shakespeare Project was launched in 2014 by Hogarth Press and challenged the established novelists to rewrite Shakespeare's plays in prose form, Winterson saw it as a "brilliant opportunity to work with [*The Winter's Tale*] in its own right" (*The Guardian*). Her novel *The Gap of Time* is the first in the Hogarth Shakespeare series, which continues the tradition established by Virginia and Leonard Woolf in 1917 "to publish the best new writing of the age" but also the "transformation of the literary past" (Hogarth Shakespeare). Having the purpose of reimagining Shakespeare's plays for twenty-first-century audiences, while staying "true to the spirit" of the originals, the project reflects some of the tensions related to the changes brought by Hogarth Press while entering a crowded market (*The Guardian*), tensions that involve the production and the perception of the works of art in the world of commodities. The obvious intention of the Hogarth Press (a division of Crown Random House Publishing) is to profit from the increased interest in Shakespeare, brought about by the anniversary years of 2014 and 2016, but while being "home for a fresh generation of literary talent" (Penguin Hogarth), it aims to create a mass-market entertainment that will benefit trade. Douglass Lanier notes that the Hogarth Shakespeare Project was launched following a significant trend in Shakespeare adaptations in recent years, particularly in theater and cinema, a tendency that has become increasingly controversial due to concerns about the "dumbing down" of Shakespeare and "the loss of respect for the power" of the poet's language (231). These concerns are exacerbated by the fact that all writers of the series have been "commissioned" to write novelized adaptations, which implies a "gain" for the writers "in terms of influence, effect, success, diffusion, readership" (Golban, 54), as well as for the mega-publisher in terms of sales. However, the intention of the contributors to the series, including Jeanette Winterson, is to "redeem Shakespeare's literariness" by revealing that "an adaptation, specifically *literary* adaptation, is the means by which the revered object can live on" and that "despite the loss of Shakespeare's language, it is nevertheless utterly faithful to Shakespeare [as] he has the power to preserve what he translates into literary form" (Lanier, 232). Furthermore, the video concludes with the final couplet of Shakespeare's *Sonnet 18* "So long as men can breathe, or eyes can see,/So long lives this, and this gives life to thee," emphasizing that Shakespeare's poetry "*cannot* capture or preserve the living creature it portrays" eternally (Lanier, 232). This awareness creates an imperative to "preserve" the past tradition, which can endure for as long as "eyes can see" and which can be attained in the present only as revisited or reimagined. Concomitantly, it becomes a challenge to the contributors to the series in general, and to Jeanette Winterson in particular, to open a space in their work to negotiate the "gaps" between the "past" and "present," the "original" and an "adaptation," "literary" and "popular" adaptations, between the thought and the artistic representation, and what is "lost" and what is "found" in the art of novelistic rewriting. Winterson's *Gap* becomes a literary manifesto in which the author confronts the long-standing stature of Shakespeare as the embodiment of elite culture and defends the legitimacy and authenticity of adaptations in an age of mass-mediatized and commercialized art and literary markets.

Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale* is a play that dwells on the idea that the present contains the past, revealed through the prophetic words of the Oracle that "the king shall live without an heir if that which is lost be not found" (III, ii, 132–3) and it becomes the leitmotif of Winterson's novel *The Gap of Time*. This is especially true since the novel is an adaptation that stresses the idea that the past can be re-found, but only if it is different in the present, the "king"/poet/canon can only live in the present if an "heir" is found to rework the past into the present. Considering that "prophet" is the biblical word for "poet," and bearing in mind the well-known roles of David as king-prophet-musician and Orpheus as poet-prophet-musician, as well as the Renaissance tradition expressed by Sidney's view of the poet as a "diviner, foreseer, or prophet" (98), and the artistic and critical legacy of high modernism established by Nietzsche's insight that "the voice of the past is always the voice of an oracle" (130), Winterson's novel *The Gap of Time* becomes a site for interrogating the authority of the oracular voice of the past, and its ability to be the "architect of the future [while having] the right to sit in the judgement of the past" (Nietzsche, 130). The novelist also engages in dialogue with T. S. Eliot's ideas from *Tradition and Individual Talent*

(1920/1950) by showing that a tradition "cannot be inherited" (Eliot, 49), since it must be acquired through great effort, in the manner of rewriting. By involving "the historical sense," the poet/artist/writer becomes deeply aware "not only of the pastness of the past, but of its presence," and is compelled to write both with "his own generation in his bones" and also on "the whole of [...] literature" (Eliot, 49). This stance of the poet, who stands in the "gap" between the temporality of their own time and the timelessness of the artistic/literary heritage, "acutely conscious of his place in time" and of "his contemporaneity" (Eliot, 49) is creatively displayed by Winterson in *The Gap of Time*. However, Winterson develops this concept further by reflecting on creativity in relation to history, innovation, and self-invention, particularly evident in her reference to Agamben's assertion that the poet "must firmly lock his gaze onto the eye of his century-beast, who must weld with his blood the shattered backbone of time" (42). The poet/artists's quest for and grasp of time is singular, unique, as it does not coincide with their own historical time but feels the disconnection and out-of-jointness, or what Agamben terms "dys-crony" (41), caused by the disrupted time, forms, and styles that mark the rupture between the mode and the object of representation in their art. Moreover, as Agamben explains, the poet of the contemporary age lives within a double fissure: the broken vertebra of the age that bridges two distinct periods and styles and the fracture between their present lifetime and the historical time. From this visionary and fractured position, the poet/artist must simultaneously bring together and hold apart their age since the poet "*is* [the] fracture, *is* at once that which impedes time from composing itself and the blood that must suture this break or this wound" (42). In Agamben's view, the poet is someone who creates a caesura: a space and time that marks a break or rupture but which is also, paradoxically, a space for meeting and healing, assuming the potentially impossible task of bringing together and holding apart their own temporalities and modes of representation, or the rupture between thought and representation. This caesural space also recalls Julia Kristeva's concept of "chora," a liminal or disruptive space that exists prior to linguistic or symbolic order, where identity and meaning await formation in a generative matrix (26). In this respect, Winterson's *Gap* becomes a literal and metaphorical space in which the novelist uses the caesurae to explore the "scars" resulting from the temporal rupture and shifts in genre and mode of representation. The "gap" opened in Shakespeare's play becomes a liminal space of transformation that enables "suturing," "welding," and healing, caused by the "shattering" of the "broken vertebrae" of the age (42–3).

Adopting a postmodern perspective based on the aesthetics of recycling and reimagining, Winterson's literary adaptation of Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale* becomes a metafictional exploration of the ways in which time and storytelling intersect. Defying the disparaging attitude toward adaptations as products of "cultural inferiority" or "supplements" (Hutcheon, 2), Winterson reveals their unique ability to be in-between the source-text and the potentiality for a new writing that examines old but also new and unexplored perspectives. This is particularly evident in the central conceit of the novel – the gap of time – which is pivotal to both Shakespeare's play and Winterson's own work.

The Winter's Tale is often categorized as "Late Shakespeare," and many scholars have observed the subtle shifts in the play's style, structure, and genre. Anselm Haverkamp notes that in his later works, Shakespeare "experiments with a new blend" and leaves them as "tentative[s] in search and experimentation, open-ended sketches of an old man who has become weary, indecisive about his art" (88). However, rather than viewing this play through the lens of "indecision," it is evident that *The Winter's Tale* embodies the outcome of Shakespeare's silent departure from the conventional five-act division, which, though formally preserved, moves toward a dual structure that Northrop Frye referred to as a "diptych" (113). By creating an unexpected "wide gap" in time, Shakespeare introduces an interruption in the "winter's tale" of Leontes's jealousy, Hermione's disgrace, and Perdita's hazardous exposure. This is a tale which Shakespeare picked up "second hand, as if by hearsay" (Haverkamp, 89) from previous sources such as Robert Green's novella *Pandosto* (1588). However, his own "improvisation" or "supplement" is marked by the temporal jump over 16 years, and it delivers the post-traumatic

redemptive experience, visualized in the apotheosis of the stone statue coming to life. This shift in time, with its implied transformations, is announced by the conventional Time, who not only signals the performability of time, but also reveals the genre shift from novella to tragedy and then from tragedy to comedy or romance, the generic fluidity that Northrop Frye views in terms of "evolving species" that turn up in a form that is opportune to the "poet [. . .] in his expression [of his] peculiar formation of symbols" (98).

The remarkable structural division of *The Winter's Tale* suggests two distinct sections that, though contrasting, come together to form a unified whole, much like a diptych that presents two separate yet related images. Winterson shows loyalty to Shakespeare's text by preserving the experimental spirit powerfully displayed in his later plays and creates her own apparent diptych: the first part, "The Original," depicts the mythical substratum present in Shakespeare's play, while the second part, named "The Cover Version," represents her departure from "The Original" and introduces her own creation. The epigraph of Winterson's novel from Robert Lowell's *For Sheridan* emphasizes that the things we "intended and failed/could never have happened –/and must be done better," and the confessional and autobiographical style of Lowell's verses alludes to the novelist's intention to revisit some of the "experimental" but confusing moments from Shakespeare's play and rewrite them "better." She picks up from the moment of the "winter's tale," resets its tone and significance to allow it a new beginning. The opening of Winterson's work is inspired by another "late" Shakespeare play, *The Tempest* (1611), with its famous words "what's past is prologue, what to come/In yours and my discharge" (II, I, 257–8). Shakespeare's intricate use of caesura inspires Winterson to create a moment of artistic ingenuity in her prologue, "The Original," which allows the past to be revisited. Though very brief, "The Original" initially gives the impression of a simple retelling of Shakespeare's play, repeating the storyline with variations. It indicates the Place "in Sicilia – one of Shakespeare's many phantasy islands," whereas the Time is "invented" (xiii). Then the setting shifts to "Bohemia. Now part of the Czech Republic. It has never had a sea-coast" (xiv) and the Time is "sixteen years later," followed by another reference to Place, just "Sicilia," without any elaborations, whereas the Time is "A fast-moving present" (6). The repetition of the Place, Time, and Story of *The Winter's Tale* creates an interruption in the historical continuum and marks a clear break from Shakespeare's text: "The end of the play, without explanation or warning or psychological interpretation, throws all the characters forward into a new life. What they will make of it is left to 'the gap of time'" (xvi). This rupture in time and story is caused by the abrupt ending of "The Original"; the empty space on the page is then followed by Winterson's novel, "The Cover Version," which is also marked by a shift from Roman numerals in "The Original" to normal numbers in "The Cover." The way Shakespeare's characters are "[thrown] forward into a new life" and the restructuring of time, together with the reference to a "cover version," suggest the novelist's desire to snap the readers out of the flow of linear history and modes of representation and expose sites of potential transformation, which are reflected in her work.

The brusque disruption in the historical continuum, together with the brisk break from *The Winter's Tale*, evokes Walter Benjamin's concept of messianic time, which challenges the Newtonian notion of "progressive" time that is perceived as a "succession," time that exists as an "absolute, true, and mathematical time, [that] of itself, and from its own nature flows equably without relation to anything external" (Newton, 17). Rather than a continuous flow, Benjamin envisages a history in which time is open to messianic ruptures, perceived by him in terms of "constellations," which Winterson refers to as "a sign of times" (6). For Benjamin, art can interrupt the linear succession of events, creating a time that stands, a "now-time," which is achieved by confronting the viewers with the truth of the injustices of history that are concealed by the metanarratives. With its unusual structure, the unexpected twists of themes and imagery, and intriguing title, *The Gap of Time* appears to interrogate the ability of art to arrest time in order to read this "sign," as the narrative continues to reflect on the issue: "But the times has so many signs that if we read them all we'd die of heartbreak" (6). The novelist particularly explores the ability of an adaptation of a Shakespearean play to make time stand and allow the past, present, and possible future to converge into the "now-time" dimension, thus creating the opportunity for restoration and transformation.

But while embarking on a query of the exceptional status of her own work, Jeanette Winterson, in *The Gap of Time*, opens a space for interrogation of the structural and philosophical aspects of Shakespeare's *Winter's Tale*, engaging clearly with Northrop Frye's critical heritage on mythic narrative and seasonal archetypes. Winterson playfully subverts the earlier-made structural reference to a diptych by arranging the novel's constitutive parts in a way that destabilizes this dual division. The novelist reimagines the impact produced by the fissure between "the original" and "the cover" by dividing "The Cover Version" into three parts, with an "Interval" between each segment. These intervals, like some intermittent gaps, signal the novelist's preoccupation with the fragmented nature of time and the disjointed aesthetic experience, a preoccupation reinforced by the frequent use of caesura – a stylistic device that is very unusual in a work of fiction.

Shakespeare is a master of caesura, as evidenced by his famous depiction of a "wide gap" in time in *The Winter's Tale*, where the pause is created to echo the consequences of the interruption for the characters' perception of their lives, histories, and self-representations. Winterson employs a similar literary technique, but the intense and frequent caesural breaks in the narrative's structure and imagery do not simply create a parallel with Shakespeare's text; they convey the visualization of a sporadic temporal line that represents the time itself as caesural. According to Agamben, "the caesura of the present" (4) separates the past and the future; it is the messianic time that creates the "gap" between the semiotic and semantic orders and the disjunction between representation and thought.

Agamben's representation of time as an intermittence, expressed as a punctual instant, divulges the impediment found in its representation, because his illustration of time, projected onto space as "the point, the line, the segment, the circle, etc.— [. . .] is responsible for a falsification that makes our time experience strictly unthinkable" (4). The same confusion arises between the eschaton and messianic time; when represented as a straight line with a definitive end, it results in "something perfectly *representable*, but absolutely unthinkable," whereas the attempt to grasp the experience of time results in "something thinkable, but strictly non-representable" (Agamben, 4).

This dilemma seems to be captured in Winterson's narrative, as the novelist conveys a time that suspends any perception of ordinary temporality and the expectation of the future, offering instead the potential within the present moment:

> Sometimes it doesn't matter that there was any time before this time. Sometimes it doesn't matter that it's night or day or now or then. Sometimes where you are is enough. It's not that time stops or that it hasn't started. This is time. You are here. This caught moment opening into a lifetime. (173–4)

This passage abruptly interrupts the flow of events, creating the impression of a suspended time, whereas the repetition of "Sometimes," followed by the recurrence of the word "time" and the listing of temporal references such as "night," "day," "now," "then" and "lifetime," conveys the imagery of an intermittent space that divulges the novelist's sense of urgency and the deep concern with temporality. This stylistic device of interval draws the readers' attention to the movement of time and to the sense of disjunction it caused, and continues to cause, expressed in terms of fear and/or awe at standing in the "moment opening into a lifetime," the messianic time. This instant imagery reflects Jean-Luc Nancy's view of poetry as a horizontal potential that unfolds in a disjointed manner, as it "is the opening or distancing of horizon itself, and in the opening: *us*. We happen as the opening itself, the dangerous fault line of a rupture" (xii). The deliberate omission of the future tenses in Winterson's passage, alongside the explicit reference to the past and present, creates the effect of out-of-jointness in the ordinary chronological progression. In this "dys-chrony," the narrative voice attempts to grasp their own time, undertaking the impossible task of representing the fractured backbone of their age. This subtle caesura is remarkable for the relationship it establishes with the messianic time:

> *the time it takes for time to come to an end, to accomplish itself*. Or, more exactly, the time we need in order to accomplish, to bring to an end our representation of time. [. . .] It is [. . .] the operational time that drives chronological time and transforms it from within; it is the time it takes us to bring time to an end – in this sense: *the time which is left to us* (Agamben, 5).

Considering that Jeanette Winterson is writing an adaptation of a Shakespearean play, the emerging imperative is not only to find unique ways of representing time, but also to step out of the position of a powerless spectator who passively observes the time running out and to make the most of time that is left, which can be achieved through the writing of her narrative. Embodying the paradigm of "operational time" (Agamben, 5), which transcends the confines of linguistics, Winterson is willing to test the limits of the plasticity and mobility of her work. This is particularly evident when "The Gap of Time" becomes the central metaphor of the narrative, as the novelist attempts to escape the rigidity of fixed genres and narrative modes by pushing the malleability of her *Gap* to assume the form of a "cover" for a song, a video game, and a work of fiction.

By transforming her work into an intermedial poetic agon, Winterson's narrative voice illustrates the Agambenian figure of the poet who stands within the intermittent fissures that mark the broken vertebrae caused by the disruption between Renaissance and Baroque art, but also between Baroque and Modernist high art, and the fracture between the historical time and the narrator's own lifetime. Instead of an elevated position as a seer, this poet/artist/narrator must hold apart these gaps in time, together with their characteristic modes and styles of representation, and also bring together, suture, or weld the shattered vertebrae of the literary heritage, using their vision to make sense of the passage of time. In this respect, Winterson becomes Shakespeare's messianic heir by employing Baroque aesthetics, visible in the elaborate and intricate stylistic devices, such as analogies, metaphors, and especially conceits, which serve as poetic tools that explore the complex or intensely emotional situations and express distorted perceptions of the things, embodying the art of things as they "seem." Winterson uses conceits lavishly in her narrative. Some of the most vivid examples include the perception of time as a gap, the discrepancy in the perception of what is "lost" and "found," or the rich conceit implied by the word "cover" (see Golban). Concomitantly, Winterson pays tribute to the Modernist aesthetic of defamiliarization or depersonalization, employed by poets to create complex images that convey a sense of surprise. This is expressed through fragmented, nonlinear time structures and a radical reimagining of language and form, so that in many instances in her work of fiction, the reader recognizes the novelist as the heir of Modernism. Winterson's engagement with Baroque art is visible in her intrusive critical interval: "Shakespeare loved disguises; one thing or one kind masquerading as another – a girl who's a boy who's a girl. A princess who is a shepherdess who is a goddess. A statue that comes to life. That things are not what they seem is the terror and the glory of *The Winter's Tale*" (288). The deliberate prosaic caesura that emerges as a result of the temporal disjunction and also from a radical break from the sophisticated language of Shakespeare functions as a tool for disenchantment, as the novelist, though paying homage to Shakespeare's legacy, must break the succession of style and imagery and "throw" the readers into a space where they can confront the textual manifestation or representation. The employed caesura disrupts the enchantment produced by the rhythmic lull of Shakespeare's magical language and tricks, jolting the reader awake at this cusp of the crepuscular and prompting them to acknowledge not only *what is* a representation and *how* it is grasped, but also the mechanics of representation itself. In other words, Winterson thrusts the existence of the veil in a representation by showing what is behind it and suggesting that the representation and mimesis are never clones of the real. Winterson's choric substratum of interval operates in a manner akin to Benjamin's lightning strike, "awaking" the reader to a recognition of liminality:

> To thinking belongs the movement as well as the arrest of thoughts. Where thinking comes to a standstill in a constellation saturated with tensions – there the dialectical image appears. It is the caesura in the movement of thought. Its position is naturally not an arbitrary one. It is to be found, in a word, where the tension between dialectical opposites is greatest. (Benjamin, 475)

In *The Winter's Tale*, the "awaking" is signaled by Autolycus's words "for the life to come, I sleep out the thought of it" (IV, iii, 29–30), and it is connected to Hermione's "magical" transformation from statue to living being: "O, she's warm!/If this be magic, let it be art/Lawful as eating" (V, iii, 109–10). In Shakespeare's play, it is suggested that art and sleep seem to "mock" what life and death become

through the power of representation, but at the same time, it expresses the need for art as it possesses the ability to triumph over life (Tambling, 44). Lanier believes that, in *The Gap of Time*, Winterson "radically downplays the scene" of Hermione's transformation, "choosing instead to treat it briefly and naturalistically" (235). However, rather than "downplaying" the moment of "awaking," Winterson transforms it into several moments of "awakening" for both the writer/artist and the reader, reconfiguring the possibilities of art in the rupturing faux of continuity: "Shakespeare walks away from the play, as we do, leaving it to the kids to get it right next time. As Ezra Pound said, 'Make it new'" (286). Empowered by the authority of the Modernist dictum "Make it new," Winterson shows that her work is not merely a contemporary substitute for Shakespeare's. Her *Gap* represents a rupture that breaks the rhythm of tradition/canon that fascinates the interlocutors and entraps them in a state of contemplation. Rather, it is the fulgurant jolt, a caesural interruption that reveals the ability to both move and arrest thought when she reimagines the mythical unit of the statue in several new instances. The first suggestion occurs when "Milo was standing like a statue" (83), recalling one of the world's most famous statues, Venus de Milo. The second instance is related to Leo's fear and fascination with Mimi, as he acknowledges that she arrests his thoughts because she is "radioactive. She had to be sealed. The memory of her had to be encased in waterproof concrete" (227), and it alludes to the myth of Pygmalion and Galatea, but in a modern manner, showing how the thought of her "threatened him." The third instance occurs when Mimi is captured in Xeno's videogame, "The Gap of Time," in which she lies

> like a tomb knight in a chapel. White and made of stone. [. . .] She was Sleeping Beauty who wouldn't wake up. [. . .] She was always here but she could be elsewhere. Walking like a statue through a statue garden. Alive and not alive. Sleeping and not sleeping. (Second Interval, no page number)

These statue-like depictions, particularly of Mimi in Xeno's videogame, convey a grotesque aesthetic by inflicting such feelings as "odd, absurd, bizarre, macabre, depraved, degenerate, [and] perverse" (Edwards & Graulund, 1). Mimi's entrapment as if in a "grotto," standing like a tomb in a chapel, half-statue, half-alive, alludes to the incongruous and striking paintings and ornaments of the exotic style known as *la grottesca* (Clark, 18), which, though displays a creepy and nightmarish mood, it also gives a jolt to a kind of "bestial flourish" (Clark, 19) due to its unique ability to set itself between the classical, formalized aesthetics and the experimental ones and signal the need for change.

Yet the most striking depiction of Mimi as a sculpture emerges when the narrative voice portrays her while strolling amidst the timeless statues in Paris and pondering on who imprisoned them in stone because she also "feels trapped in stone" (228), a deep preoccupation that sparks her meditation on the subject:

> But what sculptor out of hell had taken a living woman and rendered her flesh and carved her into a monument of herself?
>
> She was held in time as they all were, the statues, friezes, reliefs, that watched and watched over the changing city. She was one of them. (228)

In Shakespeare's play, the contrast between the statue and the spectators is evoked as an arresting experience. When the statue moves, the spectators become motionless or stone-like, showing the capacity of Baroque art to "transport" its viewers. Conversely, the statue's numbness disappears once "the fixture of her eye has motion in't," implying that the numbness of the art is now embodied within the text (Tambling, 4). Winterson radically reworks this constitutive unit of Shakespeare's play. The novelist transcends the initial impression of the male gaze in relation to the feminine ideal by exploring this preoccupation further to address the issue of art or canon as a state of imprisonment within a disorienting and threatening crypt or labyrinth. Mimi's thoughts about art as "freezing" allow her imagination to run wild, prompting her to ask questions such as "what it would be like if [it] came to life" and "who trapped [it] in stone?" (228) because she felt "trapped" on so many levels. Moreover, her thoughts turn to Michelangelo, who, she recalls, "when took a block of granite or marble he saw the figure trapped there and his duty was to free it" (228).

In her polyphonic and multilayered work, Winterson develops the motif of entrapment of art and artist, conveyed through various quotations, allusions, and references made from different artistic forms and traditions that express this anxiety and fear. The most powerful of these references is to Gérard de Nerval's Fallen Angel, as captured in Mimi's song and Xeno's video game, which, together with the mention of the poet's death by hanging, suggests the idea that poetry is trapped in its own darkness or death, whereas the poet embodies a martyr to art, since for Nerval, the "true perception requires a dissolution of the normal logic of time and identity" (Warren, 134). The reference to the fallen angel trapped in the courtyard, with his wings "drift[ing] through the windows into the dark apartments" (63), showcases the implied sacrifice, since in his attempt to escape "by opening his wings, [...] the building will collapse. But if the angel didn't open his wings he would die" (63). This "terrible story" (63), as recounted by Mimi to Xeno, alludes to Agamben's meditation on the poetic tradition whereby the poet must pay with their life for the courage to gaze into "the eyes of his century-beast [and] weld with his own blood the shattered backbone of time" (42). Winterson subverts the expectation of the mythical sacrifice of the artist in the name of art, as Mimi considers another possible outcome: "if to be free you demolish everything around you" (63). This instance recalls Agamben's suggestion that the poet "*is* this fracture" (42) and, through her characters, Winterson suggests that instead of accepting death when confronted with their own time, the poet/artist must learn from this dark, "terrible story" that while "demolish[ing] everything around" (63) him, he gains the privileged access to contemporaneity, as he is the one "who firmly holds his gaze on his own time so as to perceive not its light, but rather its darkness" (Agamben, 44). This darkness should not be seen as "a form of inertia or of passivity"; it rather implies "an activity and a singular ability" (Agamben, 45) of the poet/artist/writer to explore the demolished parts of the traditional modes of representation and rebuild in the intimate obscurity of contemporaneity a caesural space in which a new text will weld together different texts, genres, and modes, and thereby different times, in a manner that expresses transformational potential.

Defying the derogatory attitude of all those who belittle adaptation as a parasitic art that feeds off the work of others, Winterson presents her new text, *The Gap of Time*, as standing between textual fractures, as the embodiment of the vertebrae between her and the text, her text and all other texts, and between represented time and representational time. Winterson's latent reference to Shakespeare's *The Tempest*, through her mention of Miranda, evokes Prospero's final words, "Let your indulgence set me free" (Epilogue, 20), and this statement does not relate to chronological or historical time but establishes a certain positionality and relationship with her own time, through the tension displayed between distance and proximity, and "dys-chrony." This jolt from Shakespeare, to be "set free," functions as an awakening, as the poet/artist/novelist of the "now" should awaken from the existent symphony of various forces within an artwork and acknowledge that this work is merely a *gap* or interval that can orchestrate a new lucid dream and can rearrange the force lines of the canon and heritage according to the "new" terms of the "now," while challenging worlding impotence. With the courage of all poets who are bound to the world "despite its irreducible unfitness for a specifically poetic mode of existence" (Fenves, 36), Winterson creates a genuine moment of awakening, which Benjamin equates to the "now of recognizability," when the world's hidden face slips away and the entire life is staked on the "supremely dialectical point of rupture: awakening" (Benjamin, 463–4). Mimi, who delivers Winterson's message, recognizes her presence in this caesura and conveys a dialectical image in its collision with the mythical, while generating a new constitutive unit:

> She was held in time as they all were, the statues, friezes, reliefs, that watched and watched over the changing city. She was one of them.
>
> The present that disappears like water over the waterfall. The rush of time that passes so slowly and so fast. How long has it been?

> She walks to stop herself standing still. As though she could walk out of time, put it behind her where it belongs. But she can't because it's always there, right in front of her, the past is right in front of her and every day she walks slam into it like a door that locks the future on the other side.
>
> She keeps walking but nothing is moving and nothing is changing. And at the end of her morning walk when she stands still for a long time she feels that this, at least, has some reality to it.
>
> Maybe it's someone else. Maybe it's not her. There's no shortage of heartbreak. (228–9)

The deliberate use of caesura as a stylistic device, together with the invocation of caesural time, emphasizes that Winterson's *Gap* is the rupture itself: the opening of the chora to become something new, "the caesura in the movement of thought" (Benjamin, 475." The stone statue from Shakespeare's play is set free in the perpetual fluidity of the novel, affecting its readers in the process. The repetition of the word "nothing" in the above passage initially creates an impression of pessimism and futility and alludes to Leo's deluding words in Shakespeare's play, "Is whispering nothing?" (I, ii, 286). In the first chapter of "The Cover," named "The Watery Star," Shep reiterates the word "nothing" in his rage and agony at the loss of his wife, his love, and the meaning of his existence: "Nothing? Then the sky is nothing and earth is nothing and your body is nothing and our lovemaking is nothing" (14). This intense repetition of the word is somehow reminiscent of the intensity of Shakespeare's Leo in his demented speech: "The covering sky is nothing, Bohemia nothing,/My wife is nothing, nor nothing have these nothings" (I, ii, 296–7). However, while Shakespeare's character is driven to rage and jealousy by his subjective perception of events, Winterson's Shep learns from the shouting message that "EVERYTHING MUST GO" (2015: 14) and that, although the pain of loss from such a rupture never ends, it may later transform into something meaningful. Winterson reworks this constitutive unit in a surprising manner, transforming it into a conceit that perplexes with its unexpected creative analogy and functions as a moment of genuine awakening since, as she claims, "nothing *is moving* and nothing *is changing*" (229, emphasis added). In response to Shakespeare's assertion that "the *covering* sky is nothing" (I, ii, 296, emphasis added), Winterson declares that "Nothing is the key word of the play" (287). Instead of viewing it in terms of agony, insecurity, disappointment, and despair regarding the future, Winterson transforms it into a moment of self-invention in which, in an act of will based on "nothing," she causes "nothing" to move and change into "The Cover." She ingeniously reimagines Shakespeare's words "the wat'ry star" (I, ii, 1) into a new chapter to suggest that time, or its representation in art and writing, is not a continuous progression, but rather a series of gaps or intervals that exist within the messianic time that allow the possibility for change. Winterson's "watery star" emphasizes fluidity and transformation, as seen in Shep's adoption of Perdita but also in the adaptation of Shakespeare's play in Winterson's "cover." The "whispering of nothing" becomes a narrative strategy in the new adaptation to convey "loss," but it also celebrates the transformation that emerges over time as a rupture, expressing what Levinas calls "a rupture of continuity, and continuation across this rupture" (284).

In Winterson's novel, the narrative voice continues to reflect on the concept of nothing: After the nuclear wastes of Leontes's fallout, there is nothing that can be done until the next generation is ready to remedy it – and they too must first escape the necrotic longings of the past, as Perdita avoids death for a second time (288). This averted death in the text that is written "now" (or then) becomes a liminal space where a relationship with the poetics, modes of representation, forms, and structures of the past is established, while simultaneously "moving" away from them, "changing" and transforming to convey an image of immortality that Nietzsche viewed in terms of "motion" (97).

However, while acknowledging that her work is the "rupture" itself and requires transformation to avoid "death," the question arises as to the direction of this new opening. Engaging with Theodor Adorno's assertion that "caesura was to be decisive. The rupture was to become music" (241), Winterson interrogates this idea alongside Northrop Frye's genre theory. In both music and the archetypes of literature suggested by Frye, there is a succession of orders that are perceived as prophetic; yet they also create new, unstable and changing orders. Winterson subverts the order suggested by Frye's deterministic, cyclical model of literature in terms of both structure and genre,

while playfully introducing Bakhtinian dialogism as a model of utterance and inviting the reader to reconsider the hierarchy of traditional forms. The inclusion of alternative and confrontational voices signals the departure from the monological voices of the past and allows the rise of identity and difference, which become empowered in the opening space of the marketplace. The carnival spirit "recreates that special marketplace atmosphere in which the exalted and the lowly, the sacred and the profane are leveled and are all drawn into the same dance" (Bakhtin, 160). Winterson creates a genuine carnivalesque marketplace experience, particularly in Shep's piano bar, called "The Fleece," in New Bohemia, where the allusion to the clandestine and illicit Mafia, as well as to music and art, conveys a plausible setting for the kind of unofficial, deviant, topsy-turvy exuberance necessary for the ceaseless change. In a playful manner, Winterson evokes the bargaining process that accompanies buying and selling in the fast-paced environment of the marketplace, dramatized by Autolycus's trickster and roguish abilities, as he was "a dealer. A wheeler-dealer. A dealer in wheels. A soapbox salesman with a silver tongue" (135). The novelist conveys an ingenuous and stylized manner in which he sells the old car to Clo, as he tricks the young man, claiming he is buying the DeLorean car that "is NOT just a car – it's a Time Machine" (166) and "who wouldn't want the gift of time for their seventieth birthday?" (148). This instance strengthens the carnivalesque features and purposefully introduces "heteroglossia" (Bakhtin, 368), together with the multiplicity of styles borrowed from cinema, literature, and art, and is reinforced by Autolycus's suggestion that one can also go back to William Faulkner, who claimed that "*The past is not dead. It's not even past*" (166).

Since the carnival spirit corresponds to the novelistic principle itself and the dialogization is the *sine qua non* principle in the structure of the novel, Winterson employs the method of Socratic dialogue as her discursive mechanism to approach Frey's genre transformation from tragedy to romance. The transition from winter to spring is emphasized by the repeated use of "Saturday morning. Spring day" (133) in the chapter titled "Traffic," which transforms a car into a symbol of change, whereas Autolycus, the wheeler-dealer, becomes an agent who causes comic disruption through his farcical scams and silver tongue. The rich symbolic presence of CAR that GOES, with the emphasis on the question on where it is GOING (167 uppercase in original) creates another spirited dialogue with Marinetti's Futurist Manifesto (1909) that celebrated speed, and machines, and contemplated the destruction of the past. The playful subversion of all literary categories and modes is conveyed through the disguised nature of the rogue who can play endlessly with words, as in "AUTOS LIKE US" (144), which opposes the "authoritarian word" with the carnivalesque cry of "GO, GO, SHEP!" (167) that marks an opposition to official culture and allows the eruption of the marketplace's laughter, through which the archetypal trickster enables the resolution of problematic situations. However, Winterson's trickster is a performer, a showman who uses his charm and charisma to stylize and dramatize deception. The novelist reimagines Autolycus through the ingenious self-expression as a means of creating new aesthetics at a given moment. His presence also draws attention to the deceptive practices in the art world, which are frequently employed to stir what Eliot calls "new art emotion" (57), which is absolutely necessary when the value of creativity depends on sales and demand. Bearing in mind Bakhtin's assertion that "Rabelais and his contemporaries were not afraid of humor in their rendition of history; they were afraid only of petrified narrow seriousness" (78), Winterson attempts to move away from any petrifying forms, achieving her personal triumph over the past through the creation of this new, extremely fluid text.

She situates her narrative within the gap between Benjamin's assertion that time cannot be redeemed and Agambenian concept of "redeeming time" as an attempt to reveal the messianic time, or operational time. In this way, she tries to grasp and convey to her readers what Agamben refers to as "the time that we *are*, [. . .] the only real time, the only time that we *have*" (5). Moreover, as Agamben states, every poem, like any organism or temporal device, moves toward its end from the moment it begins, and that through the regular repetition of the "mechanism of the announcements and reprise of rhyme words (which correspond to the typological relation between past and future) transforms chronological time into messianic time" (Agamben, 12). Therefore, the messianic time is not related to

chronology or eternity but is a "transformation time" conveyed as "operational time," "*the time it takes the poem to come to an end*" (Agamben, 12).

Winterson makes explicit reference to "transformation time," which she portrays in her *Gap* as the sole liberator from all conventions: "And time, that sets all limits, offers our one chance at freedom from limits. We were not trapped after all. Time can be redeemed. That which is lost is found . . . " (288). Acknowledging the power but also the responsibility of holding "the time that is left," Winterson employs repetition to transform chronological time into messianic time. Recalling the novelist's description of her work as a "cover," it can be noticed the creative effort, ingenuity, and courage with which Winterson's novel stretches beyond various temporal and artistic gaps to create characters that "become surrogates of the novelist who reflects on the literary and artistic ideal which is embodied in the works whose geneses are revealed in various hypostases: as the novel itself, as a song, and as an artistic videogame" (Golban, 64). The metaphor of the creation of a work of art, together with the repeated reflections on what is "lost" and "found" in the context of a "cover" is significant, particularly given the centrality of music in Winterson's work. Through the analogy of seven stages of time and seven musical notes in an octave, Mimi's name, which, like a musical note, gains intensity through repetition, Shep's music in his piano bar, and Perdita's songs, the novelist demonstrates the integral role of music in her novel. The temporal dislocations in her narrative, as suggested by the seven stages of time and the musical structure of the songs in *The Gap of Time*, allow for simultaneous narration of experiences at the level of narrative and musical composition. This ingenious technique places the reader in the gap between intramedial artistic experiences and stimulates the affected audience to reflect on the fleeting and evanescent experiences within various temporal dimensions. Winterson's decision to use a musical term for her work of fiction may also evoke Proust's idea of discovering in music a kind of prelinguistic plenitude, "an embodiment of both a nameless longing and, [. . .] a promise of its fulfilment" (Johnson, 90). It also prompts an allusion to Milan Kundera's view of the novel as a kind of musical form, inspired by Beethoven's music, which shows that repetition, revision, and variation of themes and motifs can create the magic of transformation in a work of art.

Empowered by the voices of such influential artists and novelists who dared to bend genre boundaries, Winterson stretches the plasticity of her narrative to incorporate within its temporal and artistic frame other forms of artistic expression to convey how one, in attempting to grasp time, and with the urgency of the time that is left, creates the "most suitable" creative vessel. This effort generates a representation of an additional time that does not coincide with chronological time or the time that the novelist can depict, while simultaneously representing this time in various artistic forms. Creating the impression of "time within time" and art within art, represented by various artistic lenses of *The Gap of Time*, it conveys both time and art as an "interior" space that, like a caesura, does not close the created rupture but opens the possibility of capturing their meaning and its expression in the movement and change itself.

Returning to the idea that a work of art must offer more than mere innovation and, in its test of value, should inscribe itself as a creative work within the flux of time, Winterson surrenders herself, in an act of depersonalization, when she claims that Perdita's closing words are hers, while still playfully inscribing herself within the narrative tradition, left to posterity. The depiction of the beating heart within her body is a surprising but apt analogy of the longevity of her work:

> although history repeats itself and we always fall, and I am a carrier of history whose brief excursion into time leaves no mark, I have known something worth knowing, wild and unlikely and against every rote.
>
> Like a pocket of air in an upturned boat.
>
> Love. The size of it. The scale of it. Unimaginable. Vast. Your love for me. My love for you. Our love for one another. Real. Yes. Though I find my way by flashlight in the dark, I am witness and evidence of what I know: this love.
>
> The atom and jot of my span. (289)

The novelist's "rote," or repetition with variations, engraves her work within the messianic time as "a pocket of air" within the long tradition of intermittent attempts to depict time and love. The caesural aesthetic is further intensified by the narrative voice's inscription of the self as a seer or witness in the darkness of her era, as she struggles to find her way "by flashlight in the dark" in the singular experience of the contemporary. Through her love, she becomes the embodiment of the poet, seer or artist who gazes at the darkness within the present through the lens of a flashlight, which, though creates an optical destabilization through the temporal looking glass and prism, as well as through the reflection in art, it also delivers the promise and the potential of "the atom and jot of [her] span." Her brief presence in the "jot" of her "span" reveals once again Winterson's remarkable ingenuity. She wittily highlights her position in the gap between the immediate present and the multiple presents implied by her "jot," the gap between the historical time of the jot's settings and all the temporal layers of Shakespeare's play, where the traces of her writing on her span can be perceived "as long as eyes can see." The novel's concluding conceit reveals Winterson's ingenuity once more when she emphasizes that, despite its brevity, the jot's impact is strongly felt from one end of the space/gap/caesura to the other, "cover-ing" the transformation of "nothing" to "something" that represents the essence of her "span."

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Notes on Contributor

Tatiana Golban holds a permanent position of Professor of English and Comparative Literature at Tekirdağ Namik Kemal University, Turkey. She is the author of numerous articles, book chapters, and conference papers on various concern related to world and comparative literature and English literary studies. Her current research focuses on the adaptations of Shakespeare's plays in contemporary fiction and drama. She recently published the articles "The Lycanthropic Ambivalence within the Biopolitical Operations of the State Power in Jo Nesbo's *Macbeth*" (2024) and "The Genesis in a Nutshell? The Predicament of Being Human and Artist in Ian McEwan's *Nutshell*" (2024).

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